India's Workforce Reality Check — 2025/2026

A rough analysis on who's working, who's not, what they're earning, and what AI might change in the next 20 years.

Before you read

I wanted to get the stats on current domains where most of the 25 year olds are employed or unemployed, so I asked Claude to give me the report on the number of employees in various fields. After a bunch of questions asking it on what fields are having shortage recently and what fields are in demand, I got this detailed analysis.

Remember: this is not a survey being taken by me personally. Claude ran web searches to go through the recent resources available on the web and got the data approximately from those resources. These are just rough estimates I put together for my own studies on understanding how India has been reshaping — to understand various commonly seen roles, how many engineers India produces, recent changes in the startup ecosystem, and the overall progress.

So don't just decide by reading or going through this report. Do your own research before taking some serious decisions in your life. This is a starting point, not the final answer.

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1. Software Engineers

Metric	Number
Total SWEs in India	4.3 million (Jan 2025)
Global share	14.7% of worldwide SWE workforce
Graduates per year	1.5 million+ engineering grads
Unemployed after graduation	83% have no job or internship offer
Youth unemployment (20-24)	~44.5%
Employability rate	64% (36% not considered employable)
Entry-level hiring share	Only 15% of total IT hires in 2025
Remote for global cos	~650,000 engineers

Salary Ranges

Level	Annual Pay
Entry-level	Rs.3.5 - 6 LPA
Average	Rs.12.4 LPA
Senior (top companies)	Rs.25 - 40+ LPA
Remote for global companies	2-3x domestic rates

Key insight: *India is projected to surpass the US as the largest SWE market by 2027, growing at 11.2% annually vs US at 5.6%. But the entry-level job market is brutal — companies are skipping freshers and hiring mid-career professionals (65% of all IT hires).*

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2. Video Editors

Metric	Number
Estimated total workforce	200,000 - 500,000 (freelance + agency + production)
YouTube creative ecosystem jobs	930,000 (India, 2024)
Job security	Mostly freelance/gig-based

Salary Ranges

Level	Monthly Pay	Annual Pay
Fresher	Rs.15,000 - 25,000	Rs.1.8 - 3 LPA
Mid-level	Rs.30,000 - 60,000	Rs.3.6 - 7.2 LPA
Experienced	Rs.60,000 - 80,000	Rs.7.2 - 9.6 LPA
Film/TV editing	—	Rs.5 - 15 LPA
Senior / Post-prod lead	—	Rs.8 - 20 LPA

Key insight: *Demand is extremely high due to the short-form content boom (Reels, Shorts, OTT). But most editors are freelance with zero job security. Freelancers working with international clients earn significantly more.*

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3. Content Creators & Influencers

Metric	Number
Total active creators	4 million+
With 1,000+ followers	2 - 2.5 million
Able to monetize	Only 8-10%
Monetizing via Meta + brands	1 million+ (2024)
Revenue influenced	$350-400B in consumer spending
Creator economy (2023)	$976 million
Projected (2030)	$3.93 billion

Key insight: *90%+ creators earn little to nothing. The top 1-2% capture most of the money. India's creator monetization (8-10%) vs mature markets (40%+) gap is massive.*

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4. UX/UI Designers

Metric	Number
Designers needed across industries	62,000+
Qualified designers available	~7,000
Demand vs supply	Massive shortage

Salary Ranges

Level	Annual Pay
Fresher (0-1 yr)	Rs.2.5 - 4 LPA
Mid-level (3-5 yrs)	Rs.7.4 - 9.5 LPA
Senior (5+ yrs)	Rs.10 - 25 LPA
UX/UI Manager	Rs.8 - 45 LPA
Average (Glassdoor)	Rs.6.5 LPA
Top earners (90th %ile)	Rs.15 LPA

Key insight: *One of the few design roles where demand exceeds supply. Breaking in without a portfolio is hard, but career growth and salary progression are strong — especially at product companies.*

5. Startups

Metric	Number
Total registered startups	200,000+
New registrations (2025)	~44,000 (highest ever)
Active unicorns	~125
Shut down (2023-2025)	39,860
Shut down 2025 (Jan-Oct)	11,223 (37 per day)
Increase from 2024	30% more than 8,649
Failure rate (5 years)	~90%
Total funding 2025	$10.5B (down 17%)
Seed funding 2025	$1.1B (down 30%)
Layoffs 2023	15,000+
Layoffs 2024	10,000+
Layoffs Jan-Sep 2025	~5,649

Key insight: *India registers record startups AND record closures simultaneously. Many are "zombies" — technically alive but operating with 2 employees and no growth. 90% won't survive 5 years.*

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6. Graphic Design Industry (excl. UX/UI, video)

Metric	Number
Registered businesses	30,408
Single-owner operations	92.67%
On freelance platforms	300,000+
Entry-level salary	Rs.3.5 LPA
Experienced salary	Up to Rs.8.5 LPA

Key insight: *Almost all are solo operations. AI tools (Canva, Midjourney) are eating into lower-end work. 75% of designers now use AI. Job listings requiring AI skills jumped from 3% to 32% in two years.*

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7. Agencies

Metric	Number
Digital marketing agencies	~5,000
Annual growth rate	20-25%
Market size (2025)	$6.71 billion
Projected (2035)	$93.94 billion

Revenue Ranges

Agency Size	Annual Revenue
Small (1-5 clients)	Rs.5 - 25 LPA
Mid-sized (10-20 clients)	Rs.30 LPA - Rs.2 Crore
Large (40+ clients)	Rs.3 Crore - Rs.15 Crore+
Industry average	~Rs.1.5 Crore

Key insight: *Booming but cutthroat. Small agencies on price alone operate at thin margins or loss. Digital ad spend is overtaking traditional media for the first time in 2025.*

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8. Marketing Professionals

Metric	Number
Industry value (2025)	$6.71 billion
Projected (2035)	$93.94 billion (CAGR 30.2%)
Influencer mkt (2026)	INR 28 billion

Key insight: *Strong demand but massively flooded at entry level. Those who can demonstrate ROI, run paid campaigns, or do technical SEO are in demand. The rest struggle.*

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9. Sales Professionals

Metric	Number
Total employed workforce	643 million (FY 2024)
Gig workforce (2024-25)	1 crore (10 million)
Gig projected (2029-30)	2.35 crore (23.5 million)
Sales as category	Tens of millions across sectors

Key insight: *One of the highest-volume hiring categories. SaaS sales is fastest-growing with highest pay. E-commerce and delivery gig roles expanding rapidly.*

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10. Arts (Drawing, Music, Dance)

Metric	Number
Freelance workforce (2029-30)	23.5 million
Arts/creative share	Significant but uncounted
Formal employment	Rare — mostly self-employed
Reliable stats	Do not exist

Key insight: *Almost entirely informal. Income from performances, teaching, commissions, social media. Creator economy opening new streams but monetization rates (8-10%) remain low.*

Part 2: AI's Impact — What Gets Replaced and What Doesn't

Predictions for the next 20 years based on McKinsey, WEF, Anthropic, Bain & Company, and industry reports.

AI replaces **tasks**, not entire jobs — at least not immediately. But when enough tasks within a role get automated, the role either shrinks, transforms, or disappears. The key question isn't "will AI take my job?" but "how much of my daily work can AI already do?"

High Risk: Significantly replaced (next 5-10 years)

Domain	Why it's vulnerable	What survives
Data entry & back-office	Purely repetitive. JPMorgan automated 20% of back-office.	Nothing
Basic customer support	Chatbots handle FAQs. Salesforce cut 4,000 roles.	Complex escalations
Telemarketing	AI voice agents make thousands of calls simultaneously.	Relationship-based B2B
Basic content writing	Product descriptions, templated blogs commoditized.	Strategy, thought leadership
Translation (standard)	Near-human accuracy on business/technical docs.	Literary, cultural, legal
Junior graphic design	AI design tools. WEF ranks it fastest-declining.	Brand strategy, creative direction
Basic bookkeeping	Automated invoicing, expense tracking.	Auditing, tax strategy
Financial trading	AI processes market data faster and cheaper.	Risk mgmt, client relationships
Travel agents	AI search, personalization, virtual tours.	Luxury/complex consulting

Moderate Risk: Transformed but not fully replaced (10-15 years)

Domain	What changes	What stays human
Software engineering	AI writes boilerplate, automates testing. Junior roles shrink.	Architecture, system design, business context

Domain	What changes	What stays human
Marketing & SEO	AI automates reporting, A/B testing, ad optimization.	Brand positioning, creative campaigns
Video editing	Auto-cut, color grade, transitions automated.	Storytelling, editing for emotion
Legal (junior)	Contract review, case research automated.	Courtroom, negotiation, ethics
Data analysis	AI generates dashboards, finds patterns.	Right questions, context, communication
Sales (transactional)	Lead scoring, outreach, CRM automation.	Complex B2B, relationship building

Low Risk: Won't meaningfully replace (next 20 years)

Domain	Why AI can't replace it
Healthcare	Physical presence, emotional intelligence, accountability. Nurses projected +45.7% by 2032.
Skilled trades	Physical, on-site, unpredictable. Every job different. Projected +6% by 2032.
Education (early childhood)	Children need warmth, attachment, social modeling.
Mental health & counseling	Empathy, trust, emotional attunement. AI supports, can't replace.
Emergency services	Chaotic, physical, instant human judgment in life-or-death.
Senior leadership	Vision, culture, conflict resolution, ethical trade-offs. 80% stays human.
Creative direction	Deciding what should exist. Original thinking, cultural context, taste.
Cybersecurity (senior)	Adversarial, evolving. Humans handle complex defense and strategy.
Live performing arts	Value is in human presence, not output.
Construction & field work	Unpredictable environments, poor documentation, every site different.

The 61-point gap

Anthropic's 2026 labor market study found a **61-point gap** between what AI can technically do (94% of knowledge work tasks) and what it actually does in practice (33%). The capability is there. The adoption is slow. This gap will close over 10-20 years, but not overnight.

What this means for career decisions

If you're 20-25 right now, pick work at the intersection of:

1. Human judgment — context, ethics, and trade-offs matter more than speed

2. Physical presence — you need to be somewhere, touching something, reading a room

3. Relationship depth — trust built over time, can't be automated

4. Creative strategy — "what should we build?" not "how do we build it?"

Safe domains: healthcare, skilled trades, cybersecurity, senior engineering, creative direction, education, mental health, complex B2B sales.

At-risk domains: data entry, basic content writing, templated design, standard translation, Tier 1 support, routine bookkeeping.

Middle ground: software dev, marketing, video editing, graphic design, data analysis, junior legal. These transform dramatically. Thrive by moving from production to strategy.

> *AI doesn't care about your degree. It cares about the nature of your tasks. The worst position is a role that's "kind of automatable" and doing nothing about it. The best position is understanding both the domain AND the AI tools well enough to be irreplaceable.*

Sources

Employment & Workforce Data

Unstop Talent Report 2025 — 83% engineering grads unemployed

Quess Corp — IT Workforce Trends 2025 (1.8M roles, 16% growth)

Wheebox — Engineering graduate employability India

Software Engineer Statistics India 2025 (4.3M SWEs)

Engineering Graduate Job Crisis 2025

25 Job Statistics India 2025

PLFS India — 643M employed

PIB India — 17 crore jobs added

IT Hiring Trends 2026 (7.5M tech workforce by 2030)

Creator Economy & Media

Ikigai Law — Creators First Report (4M+ creators)

Hollywood Reporter India — Creator A-List 2025

India Creator Economy Market Forecast 2026-2033

Kotak — India Creator Economy (8-10% monetization)

Design & Graphics

Graphic designers in India (30,408 businesses)

Graphic Design Statistics 2025 (300K+ freelancers)

Future of Design Industry in India

Graphic Design Job Market 2025

Salary Data

Video Editor salary — Indeed India

Video Editor salary — PayScale India

UI/UX Designer salary — Glassdoor India

UI/UX Designer salary 2025

UI/UX Designer salary — upGrad

Startups

Why Startups Fail in India (39,860 closures)

India Startup Reckoning 2025 — Deutsche Consulting

PM Modi — 44,000 startups registered 2025

40K Failed Startups in India — Jasaro

India Startup Ecosystem 2025 — TICE News

Startup Statistics 2026 — DemandSage

Startup Failure Statistics 2026 — GrowthList

Agencies & Marketing

Digital Marketing Agencies in India (~5,000)

Digital Marketing Agency Revenue India

India Digital Marketing Market Size

AI & Future of Work

What Jobs Will AI Replace — AI Risk Calculator

Jobs AI Already Replaced — Agility Portal

65 Jobs Safest from AI — US Career Institute

What Jobs Will AI Replace — Built In

15 Jobs AI Will Replace by 2030 — Gaper

10 Jobs AI Won't Replace — PrometAI

Jobs AI Will Replace by 2030 — Softude

This report was compiled using Claude's web search across multiple recent sources. Numbers are approximate and should be verified independently before making career or business decisions.